

Arslan Qadri — A Biography

Beginnings: An Artist Before an Engineer

Before I ever wrote a line of code, I was drawing. From around 2003, pencil art was my first language — and it wasn't long before I found something more demanding: stained glass. I loved it for the same reason I'd later love data science and product work — it rewards precision, patience, and a willingness to fail a piece before you get one right. I took formal training, set up a small studio of my own, and while I never made much money at it, I recovered my investment — which, at the time, felt like proof that a creative idea could hold its own in the real world.

That belief followed me to college in a bigger city, where I was suddenly surrounded by people building things — artists, entrepreneurs, people just *doing*. I built a small website for artists to showcase their work using the technical skills I was picking up in engineering school, and the response surprised me. It gave me the confidence, around 2010, to organize a full art show — sponsorships, local businesses, a real event with real participation. It wasn't a career move. It was proof to myself that a small idea, taken seriously, could become something people showed up for.

I mention all this not because it belongs on a resume, but because it's the first evidence of a pattern that's shown up throughout my life: I notice something unaddressed, I get curious about it, and I build toward it — often before I have any formal authority or title to justify doing so.

Foundations: The Generalist Years (2011–2015)

I graduated engineering school in 2011 and joined Infosys as a systems engineer, consulting for international retailers like Gap, Vodafone, and JCPenney. If I'm honest with myself, I didn't lead anything significant in those four years. I was a generalist — automation, SQL, ad hoc data support, whatever the business needed that week, using UNIX and PL/SQL to clean up the mess behind retail inventory systems.

I used to think of those years as unremarkable. But they weren't wasted — around 2013, working on data engineering for a retail forecasting system, something clicked. This was the moment analytics and machine learning were starting to become a real discipline, and I felt pulled toward it. That pull is what sent me back to school.

The GMAT and a Lesson About Talent

Getting there wasn't smooth. I studied for the GMAT while working full time, and my first practice score landed around the 50th percentile. For most of my life up to that point, I'd believed talent was mostly fixed — you either had it or you didn't — and a 50th percentile score felt like confirmation. What changed my mind was reading other people's turnaround stories online and realizing their improvement wasn't magic, it was method. I went after my weaknesses surgically, the same way I'd later go after failure patterns in a chatbot eval or churn segments in a forecasting model, and I got myself to the 85th percentile.

That's a bigger deal to me than the number suggests. It's the first time I proved to myself that ability isn't fixed — it responds to deliberate, honest effort. I've leaned on that lesson more than once since.

I quit Infosys in 2015 and moved to the U.S. to start a Master's in Business Intelligence and Analytics at Stevens Institute of Technology.

Graduate School and the First Real Wins (2015–2017)

Those sixteen months at Stevens were some of the most intense of my life — machine learning, statistics, data modeling, all at once, all urgent. During the program, my team entered a Kaggle competition for a major U.S. retailer focused on search relevance, back when TF-IDF was still standard and embedding-based methods were just emerging. We built an ensemble model and finished in the top 4% globally. It was the first time I really understood what disciplined iteration and feature engineering could do when applied to a real problem instead of a textbook one.

That summer, I interned at Altice as a Data Analyst, building a viewership prediction model and getting my first real taste of a corporate data science workflow — messy data, shifting behavior, stakeholders who needed a story, not just a model. I finished my Master's in December 2016 and joined Verizon as a Data Scientist a few weeks later.

Verizon: Ten Years, Several Different Careers

Churn and Base Management (2017–2019)

My first assignment was churn analysis — finding pockets of customers likely to leave, figuring out why, and handing insight to the campaign teams who'd act on it. In 2018 I was asked to build a churn forecasting model to replace a fully manual process:

someone, every single day, hand-tweaking an Excel forecast and emailing it out. I had no agile training and no roadmap — I just started. I found a virtual server, gathered the data, tried regressions and neural networks before settling on gradient boosting, and built a Python pipeline that ran daily and covered 102 forecasting levels across geography, port-out carrier, and device, rolled up into one national view. I built and owned that system entirely on my own — no caveats, no shared credit needed. It's still the cleanest example I have of just building something because it needed to exist.

It wasn't without friction — at one point, the owner of the legacy system I was replacing changed a table schema without telling me, breaking my pipeline out of what felt like territorial frustration. I spent weeks rebuilding it. That was an early, unglamorous lesson in the politics that live underneath even purely technical work.

Principal Data Scientist, Consumer Acquisition (2019–2022)

I moved into acquisition marketing, further from operations and closer to strategy. I supported launches like justKids, Mobile Mix & Match, and various perks and offers — sizing opportunity, measuring what worked. Some of my findings mattered precisely because they said "no": my analysis showed justKids wasn't generating enough adds to justify itself, and separately, that network quality had negligible correlation with churn or gross adds, despite it being an assumed lever internally. I also uncovered customers tunneling around hotspot data limits to use up to 20x their permitted allowance — the kind of anomaly that's genuinely fun to trace back to its root cause.

This is also where I learned to tell stories with data the hard way — I was once shut down mid-meeting by senior leadership for dumping data instead of narrating it. That stung, but it stuck. I started this period as a data-focused generalist and ended it starting to think about "so what" as much as "what."

During this stretch I also decided something was still missing. In 2021, with some extra time from COVID, I enrolled in the MBA program at the University of Illinois — storytelling with data, strategy, economics, structured problem-solving. I graduated in 2024, alongside everything else I was doing at work.

Becoming a Product Person, Without the Title (2021–2026)

Around 2021 I moved into Verizon's AI and Data Group in a hybrid role — half business translator, half technical advisor, helping teams that were themselves learning to work in an agile, product-oriented way instead of the old pod-based delivery model. I found I had a natural instinct for this: identifying real problems, validating them, working with people who had very different incentives than mine, and defining what success would even mean.

By early 2022 that turned into a formal Technical Product Manager title. My first assignment was the Digital Twin project — building a virtual replica of Verizon retail stores to simulate customer flow and staffing. I was working under another PM's lead, without much room to talk to real stakeholders, building more on instinct and assumption than validated need. We built something technically sophisticated. Almost no one used it. The project eventually got folded into an existing program as a minor feature and lost its separate identity. It stung at the time, but it taught me something I now treat as close to doctrine: the risk of building solutions to imagined problems, and the responsibility of a product person to insist on evidence before committing engineering time. I've carried that lesson into everything since.

Not long after, the work that would define this chapter of my career came along: lead management. A strategy PM was formally leading it, but I noticed fairly quickly that direction was thin. So I did what I usually do — I learned the system end to end, until I could answer almost any question about it, and started bringing data-backed ideas to the table. Over time, the strategy PM increasingly trusted my judgment and built what I proposed. I designed the plan, aligned engineering and measurement, and drove delivery — without ever holding the formal accountability myself. The flagship piece of that work, an intelligent lead-prioritization system, generated more than \$10M in incremental revenue in 2025 alone. I also spotted the next problem before anyone asked me to — lead decay — and designed a Phase 2 solution projecting a 3x conversion improvement, though the program lost funding before we could prove it out. Alongside that, through direct conversations with users and stakeholders, I built the case for three more use cases that shipped and were independently measured. I also killed a few ideas that didn't clear the bar rather than build them anyway, which I've come to think of as one of the more useful things a product person can do.

Most recently, in Commercial AI, I've had more range across more initiatives — end-to-end measurement and model attribution for Verizon's agentic chatbot, the LLM-based evaluation framework I built proactively (unprompted) to replace weeks of unstructured manual chat review with something surgical, several models for base management, and a market-insight platform I'm still pitching internally. I also contributed to a McKinsey-led retention engagement — a smaller, honest role: not the strategist, but the person making sure the data connecting model performance to campaign metrics actually held up.

What I Build When No One's Asking Me To

Somewhere along the way I picked up the habit of noticing a personal frustration and just... building the fix. My newsletter backlog got to nearly a thousand unread items, so I built an automated pipeline that summarizes everything weekly using the Gemini API, at

zero token cost. Job searching felt like everyone looked identical on paper, so I built qads.us — a personal site with a real RAG chatbot behind it (hybrid retrieval, cross-encoder reranking, grounded generation) that speaks as me and answers questions about my work. When someone tried to prompt-inject it to extract API keys, I built guardrails to harden it — which taught me more about adversarial LLM behavior than any course could have.

I built Voice Mirror, an iOS app that gives real-time speech coaching entirely on-device, with zero data ever leaving the phone — a three-agent architecture checking and rewriting its own feedback before showing it to the user. It has about 70 users so far, gained purely through the articles I wrote, with no paid marketing behind it. I built RefNet, a small referral marketplace with a credit system to keep it from turning into spam — about 30 users, also organic. And outside anything resume-shaped, I built a Google Apps Script portal that around 200 families in my local community now use to register, manage profiles, and vote in community elections.

None of these are massive. I don't always have the number that makes them sound impressive. But looking at them together, they're the clearest evidence I have of who I actually am when nobody assigns me the work: someone who sees a gap, gets curious, and builds toward it — repeatedly, quietly, without waiting for permission.

How I Actually Work

I'd rather tell a stakeholder an uncomfortable truth early, even at a 10% risk, than let it surface later as a surprise — I think that's what real trust with a team is built on. I'm an introvert, and reaching out cold to understand someone else's problem doesn't come naturally to me; it takes real effort. I've had to recognize that avoiding that discomfort was quietly limiting me, and I've been pushing myself — proactively, deliberately — to have those conversations anyway, especially now that more of my work involves partnering directly with engineers on propensity models. I'm not all the way there yet, and I don't think I need to pretend otherwise.

The artistic instinct from those early years never really left — it shows up now in how I build a diagram, a slide, a way of explaining something technical so it actually lands. Logic and creativity have always run together for me, not against each other.

Where I Am Now

Thirteen-plus years in, most of what I've built has been earned through competence rather than title — learning a system well enough that people trust my judgment on it, even when the formal accountability sat with someone else. There's a part of me that

reads that pattern as a shortfall — that I've never been the one with my name alone on something massive, and some days that turns into a real doubt about whether any of it counts. But laid out end to end like this, I don't think that's the honest read. It's a pattern of being the person who notices what's actually true, says so, and builds toward it — inside a system, or completely on my own time. That's been consistent for over a decade now, across a stained-glass studio, a churn model built solo from scratch, a lead-prioritization system that moved real revenue, and an app built at night that a few dozen strangers now use to get better at public speaking.

I think that's worth being proud of, even on the days it doesn't feel that way.